

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 6: *Alienation from Self*¹

“The Son of Man came to seek and to save that which was lost.”² The Son of Man is Jesus, who is the perfect model for human beings. He inquires after, hunts for and seeks, requires, and even demands what has been lost, and we are to follow His example. His mission is to rescue and then keep safe the lost thing, which we believe is a person—your real self.

Kidnapping and ransom demands plagued all the affluent families in first century Rome. Those who were kidnapped became slaves or simply languished in captivity with small hope of rescue, unless someone paid the huge price of time and resources required to find and redeem them. Finding and redeeming the real self requires a similarly great effort. In the beginning of our recovery, we must redirect what seems like an exorbitant amount of our time and energy to seek and to save, or rescue, that which was lost.

When we are committed to saving the life of our idealized self, we cannot have a genuine connection with Jesus. The idealized self is far too vulnerable and shallow to allow for the kind of reality that Jesus requires in a relationship. He is, after all, the Truth, and as neurotics, we are afraid of the truth. We may think that we are in relationship with Him, but then why are we so often anxious, angry, self-defensive, and subject to self-sabotage? We will sacrifice our potential and even the well-being of others to save our idealized lives. Any interference with our search for glory is perceived as a threat—and Jesus is a big threat to the idealized self. He just won’t give up until He has established with His own creature a real relationship that allows Him to reveal the truth about who He designed that creature to be.

When Nancy first read *Neurosis and Human Growth* in 1998, she recognized the pride of the idealized self in her theological beliefs, her words, and in everything she did, especially in her ministry. She realized that she had rebelled against her Creator by trying to avoid the hard work of becoming the glorious creature He designed her to be. Instead, she tried to make herself in her own image and then presented that self to Jesus like the people in Matthew 7:23 who said, “See, Jesus, see, aren’t I special? I’m doing all these wonderful things, and in Your name, too!” Yet Jesus will reply to those people, “Depart from Me, I never knew you.” In our neurosis, there is very little to know; we are lost—and we will never find ourselves if in our pride we choose to remain alienated from Him.

When we make the decision to co-labor with Jesus in the difficult work of seeking and rescuing our real self, we can be confident that He will guide and support us. We can trust Him. He created us and He knows how to find us. Think of the shepherd who goes searching for his lost lamb. When he rescues the one that he recognizes as his own, he feels great joy. You, also, will feel great joy when you catch glimpses of your real self, for only from that real person can the rivers of living water flow.³

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

² Luke 19:10.

³ John 7:39.